

LOCAL TO GLOBAL
Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a BJP rally in Hyderabad, Nov. 7; (right) he arrives along with G20 leaders at Rajghat in Delhi, Sept. 10

cent of the seats in the Lok Sabha and state legislatures would be reserved for female candidates. Modi described it as the next big step for boosting "Nari Shakti" and to spur a "women-led development" of the country. He would face criticism from the Opposition, though, for deferring its implementation till after the 2026 delimitation process for parliamentary constituencies that is also likely to increase the number of seats from the 543 presently.

In December, the Supreme Court vindicated another daring reform of Modi's by upholding the abrogation of Article 370 which his government had effected in August 2019. It brought legal closure to the special status given to Jammu and Kashmir under the Indian Constitution that had been hanging fire since Independence. In an exclusive interview to INDIA TODAY at his residence on December 26, the prime minister was clear that "Article 370 is gone for ever" and that the "people of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh are for the first time free to shape their destinies in their own hands". On his approach to pushing through tough reforms of the nature of women's reservation and the abrogation of Article 370, the prime minister says, "People often ask me about how I could take such a difficult decision. For me, it does not seem difficult as I take all my decisions through the single prism of Nation First."

THE BUILDER

In 2023, Modi the Builder also stepped into the limelight. In September, the prime minister inaugurated the new Indian Parliament which he put on the 'superfast-track' and got ready in 28 months despite delays caused by the Covid pandemic. If the 1927-vintage Parliament sufficed for 96 years with its familiar circular shape, the new Sansad combines tradition with modernity and is designed to take care of the country's needs in terms of expansion of representation for a full century and beyond. Not far from Parliament, Modi revamped another monumental complex, Pragati Maidan, which now includes a world-class convention centre called Bharat Mandapam. This was again done at top speed, in time to showcase it for the G20 summit, the largest gathering of the world's most powerful leaders. There is a third structure that has come up under Modi's watchful eye, the Ram temple at Ayodhya, that will be consecrated by him on January 22, 2024. Coming just four months before the Lok Sabha election, along with the abrogation of Article 370, it is likely to consolidate the Hindutva vote.

BJP president J.P. Nadda says Modi always wants a wider choice and pushes for more youngsters to be brought into leadership roles

Modi exhibits a mystifying duality in his actions. Even while he strengthened his Hindutva plank with his moves on Kashmir and Ayodhya, he strode down the path of economic development and growth, fashioning himself not just as a Protector of the Faith but also as a Messiah of the Poor.

MESSIAH OF THE POOR

In Modi's first term, the focus had been on construction of toilets, free gas connections, health cards to meet hospital expenses and housing for the poor. At the start of his second term, Modi announced a massive scheme called Har Ghar Nal to provide 192 million households with drinking water on tap for Rs 3.5 lakh crore. When it was launched on August 15, 2019, only 16 per cent of the households had drinking water connections. As of December 2023, that percentage has gone up to 72 per cent with 130 million households covered.

Modi's welfare schemes now cover almost every aspect of the life of the poor. In his interview, he calls it the "progressive unfolding of my vision and plans". Elaborating on what that curious line means, he explains, "When